



Awards and Accolades

Dr Mahesh Gupta's efforts have been recognised both in India and at the international level as follows:

- Distinguished Alumnus Award by IIT Kanpur 2011
- Asia's Most Promising Leader by World Consulting Research Corporation 2016
- Business Leader of the Year - Water Management by CHEMTECH CEW Leadership Excellence Awards 2019
- Swachh Bharat Ambassador by the Government of India in 2016
- Kalam Innovation Governance Award by Kalam Innovation in Governance Award, 2016
- Doctor of Philosophy (Honoris Causa) by Sri Sri University 2015

Besides the above-mentioned achievements, his brand Kent RO system was also awarded by many reputed national and international bodies.

Mahesh describes his school experience at Diwan Chand Arya Public School as a humble but spiritual experience. He picked up some of the spiritual lessons at an early age from his school. In the later stage of life, he found a great spiritual mentor and continues his spiritual learning to date.

He recalls some of his school-teachers, especially his physics teacher who used to take additional classes for meritorious students without any fee. "I was the topper at my school. I remember one of my school friends, Rakesh, with whom I used to enjoy a healthy competition for the top spot and together learned a lot. Later on, he went to IIT Delhi. Eventually, our professional paths crossed again, and we equally enjoyed solving work-related challenges," Mahesh reminisces.

Mahesh is a fantastic example of a tactile learner who always prefers to learn by doing. In school days, he used to get hold of any subject matter by attentively attending school classes and never depended on any private tuition. He used to apply the learning by teaching philosophy effectively as he says, "I learned quite a lot in my education by teaching my classmates. Once you teach people and clarify their doubts successfully, you can learn more."

Mahesh believes, "If you attend a class of a good teacher with 100% attention, you do not need to burn the proverbial midnight oil. However, if you are not attentive in class, then

you need to have a private tutor."

The tactile learning process helped Mahesh acquire business acumen through life experiences. He shares an interesting anecdote about learning business skills. In his words, "I started visiting the local market at an early age of nine years, as then my elder brother was in IIT, and my father did not get time to go to market due to his work pressure. Therefore, I was responsible for vegetable and grocery shopping."

He continues, "My family was quite a big one and my mother used to send me to the market with a limited amount of money. That early life experience taught me many business skills. I started learning negotiation, budgeting, and bargaining to pay the lowest price without compromising on quality. These skills later helped me in my entrepreneurial journey as well."

Mahesh's quest for knowledge prompted him to work on low-cost models and experiments related to physics, like magnetic and electrical models. Because of his interest in hands-on experimentation, he was good at mechanical repairing.

He remembers, "I was good at repairs. Once I had repaired a bicycle mechanically just by hand. I could repair a television or radio during my school days. Even today if anything comes to me that needs to be done by hand." This knack for mechanical applications also influenced him to select mechanical engineering as the stream for higher education.

Mahesh mentions, "In my childhood, many people used to ask me what I would like to become. Therefore, my vision for future study was quite clear from fifth standard only. My decision was influenced by my brother who had opted for IIT and my interest in engineering. I was quite focused on pursuing higher education at IIT. After school, I sat for the IIT entrance examination and was admitted to IIT Kanpur to pursue a mechanical engineering degree without any hurdle."

Mahesh recalls his engineering days as a period to learn how to survive and win in a highly competitive environment. He explains, "I was a topper at my school. So, I used to think of myself as the best student. However, at IIT I faced real competition. Once you are among the best students you can see people who are much better than you. However, I took the challenge to prove myself there. The third-semester examination used to be considered the toughest one at IIT Kanpur. I passed that exam with an A grade in all five subjects." He also enjoyed the learning environment at IIT with an excellent peer group.

Following the entrepreneurial instinct

Soon after completing his engineering degree in the year 1976 Mahesh began his professional journey. Mahesh recalls, "I came up with flying colours from IIT Kanpur and immediately went to pursue a master's in petroleum engineering from the Indian Institute of Petroleum, Dehradun. After completing my master's degree, I joined Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL) as my father dreamed that I should get into the public sector."

Mahesh worked in Indian Oil for about ten years. He says, "It was a great learning opportunity as I was asked to go all over the country to several factories, audit them for sav-